



matches last season, while sides qualifying through the playoffs played 28.

The media rights have nosedived too, falling from Rs. 1.69 crore per match to Rs. 9.5 lakh per game, a decline of 94.4 per cent.

In contrast, a regional league like Super League Kerala (SLK), with fewer teams (6 vs 14) and fewer matches than the ISL (33 vs 91), sold its media rights for Rs. 100 crore for the next five years. That takes its per-match valuation to Rs. 60.6 lakh,

nearly seven times that of the ISL.

The SLK, in its second season, has an average attendance of 12,553. The ISL, after 10 seasons, has seen its average attendance fall from 25,408 in the first season to 11,084.

Meanwhile, several clubs implemented pay cuts for players to get ISL 2025-26 underway, including Super Cup champion FC Goa.

"Our First Team players and Technical Staff stepped forward, stood together, and chose to support the club by agreeing to

**Hard reset:** The Indian Super League (ISL) will finally start its new season on February 14. AIFF MEDIA

reduce their remuneration during this period. This was not an easy decision. It was a selfless one," FC Goa said in a statement.

So did Bengaluru FC, led by captain and India's record goalscorer Sunil Chhetri.

Player salaries have been the Achilles heel for clubs, especially in a